

Protocol Into Petitional Prayer

The Prayer of Faith Requires Character Before It Requires Technique

Thank You, Jesus.

Over the years, He has taught me much about the supernatural walk of the Spirit and the walk of power. That is, the steps you begin to take in mortifying the flesh and walking after Him until you are conformed to Jesus' image from glory to glory. Through the Spirit, you mortify the deeds of the body until you are walking in a measure of holiness, character, and standards.

For most of those years we have majored on praying in the Holy Ghost, because I knew that when you pray in the Holy Ghost, although at the time of prayer He may leave your mind out, He is praying the best prayer that could possibly be selected for your life. We talked much about that because I knew that eventually, in the Spirit, He would build you up on your most holy faith. Through edification and those things, you would come to such a place in character that when you were taught the prayer of faith, you would have the character to stand up under it when you proclaimed it.

Then He released me about the first of the year to begin to teach on actual petitionary faith, petitionary prayer, what we have classified as the prayer of faith. Each time you make a cycle into something to teach on it, because of the foundation He has already laid, it seems He is able to put another framework on it, another story. You understand more each time.

This time, in teaching petitionary prayer or the prayer of faith, I began noticing things I had never seen before.

One thing that puzzled me about entering the presence of God with a petition was this: if He already knows what we have need of before we ever enter His presence to pray, why bother? Does He like the sound of our voice? Does He want us to articulate it? Is it necessary to go before Him and pray our needs in order for Him to answer them?

If He already knows what we have need of before we pray, then why does He want us to come into His presence and present a petition?

When Jesus taught on prayer in Matthew 6, the disciples had seen Him praying and asked Him to teach them how to pray. But before they ever offered their petition, He said that when you enter into the presence of your Father, you do so by saying, "Hallowed be Thy name."

Most of us picked up on the actual petition of prayer and what it needed to contain based on the Word, but we did not really understand what was prerequisite to presenting the petition. We did not understand what had to be present in our lives when we approached Him to present our petition.

I called it prerequisite, but finally the Holy Spirit whispered the word protocol. There is a proper way to approach the Godhead with your petition.

Since we have been teaching on this for about a month, how many of you have already seen some of the petitionary prayers you have been presenting before Him begin to come to pass? Raise your hand. Already. I have.

This petitionary prayer operates especially powerfully when somebody is on your heart and you want that person saved. When you zero in and begin to petition God on that person's behalf, it sets the whole corporate structure of heaven into operation. Angels position themselves. The Holy Spirit begins to send everyone He can to them. It literally creates a heavenly atmosphere around that person. Angels come and create a perimeter. The final decision is still theirs, but the whole corporate structure of heaven goes into operation to see that your mountain-moving prayer, your petition of faith, has every opportunity to come to pass.

Since we have been teaching the prerequisites, or the protocol, for entering the presence of your King, how many know it has made a difference? It has brought your consciousness to an awareness that we are dealing with God. If anyone ever deserved your respect, ever knew your weaknesses, and ever should be approached correctly, it is your Redeemer. It is your Lamb. It is your Father God.

Amen.

God Already Knows the Need, So Protocol Honors Who He Is

This is the verse that got me into prerequisites. Look at Matthew 6:7:

But when ye pray, use not vain repetitions, as the heathen do:
for they think that they shall be heard for their much speaking.
Be not ye therefore like unto them:
for your Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask him.
After this manner therefore pray ye:
Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name.

He already knows. Before you ever entered His presence, He already knows. So He said, "Pray after this manner: Our Father which art in heaven, hallowed be Thy name." Then He goes on to give what we have classified as the Lord's Prayer.

Jesus stood there in the flesh as the Word and the Son of God, teaching His disciples how to enter into the presence of the Father. He told them not to be like the heathen, who do not give their god the respect of knowing that he already knows their needs before they approach him. Jesus said, "Your heavenly Father knows."

So treat Him with the respect due to the fact that He does know. Repetition will not get your prayer answered. This is why He taught on protocol. There must be things present in my life when I approach Him if I expect my prayer or petition to be heard.

Jesus was standing there teaching us how to enter into the presence of God.

After Judas betrayed Him, Jesus washed Judas' feet. Then Judas lifted up his heel against Him and went away to get the soldiers and the money. Between the time Judas went to get the soldiers and priests to arrest Him and the time they came to take Him, Jesus entered into teaching on the Holy Spirit.

Up until that time, He really had not taught on the Holy Spirit the way He did in those last days. He knew His hour was approaching, and it was expedient that He go away, so He began a tremendous teaching on the Comforter and His coming.

He began that teaching by saying:

He dwelleth with you, and shall be in you.

It was impossible for Him to be in them at that time because they were unregenerated. They were not born again. They could not be until Jesus was resurrected. This is why He told Peter, "I have prayed for you that your faith fail not. When you are converted, strengthen your brethren." In other words, when you are born again, turn around and strengthen them.

Jesus ministered in an unusual time between two covenants. He was at the end of the old, yet teaching the principles of the new. He said, "The law and the prophets were until John. Since that time the kingdom of God is preached." He was preaching it. Every man would press into it.

So He said, "He is with you, and in that day He shall be in you." He left the ministry and power of the Holy Spirit resident with them while He went through crucifixion and resurrection. Then they were born again.

In those last days He taught the ministry of the Holy Spirit:

It is expedient for you that I go away:
for if I go not away, the Comforter will not come unto you.

The same way Jesus taught them how to enter the presence of the Father when He was with them, the Holy Spirit would teach them how to enter Jesus' presence. He would not speak of Himself. What He hears, He speaks. He glorifies Jesus. He teaches you how to partake of Jesus. He teaches you how to go from glory to glory into His express image.

The Holy Spirit's ministry, beginning with your rebirth, is to reveal Christ in you, to bring you into the presence of Jesus. Then Jesus can take you into the presence of the Father with your petition.

The Holy Spirit brings me into the presence of Jesus. Then Jesus said a day was coming when "ye shall ask Me nothing." The Father Himself will love you, and whatever you ask Him in My name, He will give it to you.

Up until that time, Jesus did their praying for them. He approached the Father for them. When they needed prayer answered, they asked Him, and He prayed for them.

They even caught a man casting out devils and healing the sick in Jesus' name. They thought it was their job to stop him because he was not one of them. Jesus said, "He that is not against us is for us."

In that day, Jesus said, "You will ask Me nothing." I have been doing all your praying for you, but in that day I will have administered an abundant entrance into the presence of the Father with My own blood. Whatever you ask the Father in the name of the finished work, everything I have provided, He will do it.

Therefore, when you enter the presence of Jesus with worship, you do so because He finished the work. Two thousand years ago, when He said, "It is finished," He made provision for every need you could ever have or ever aspire to have. There is nothing He did not provide for.

In entering the presence of Jesus, He is worthy of all the worship you can give Him for provision, because He paid the price. It cost Him everything to provide the finished work for answered prayer. It is that name you carry into the presence of your Father.

Hallelujah. It makes me want to stop and pray a while.

Praise Him for His Word for a minute or two. Hallelujah. Glory be to God. Hallelujah, Jesus. I glorify You and praise You and thank You for Your Word. You said we would know the truth, and the truth would make us free.

Hallelujah, Jesus. I want to know how to enter Your presence, and I will not quit teaching on it until You release me.

You can be seated.

Protocol Means Learning How to Enter the King's Presence

I can see the look on some of your faces: "Oh no, not the old yellow pages." Be of good cheer. I only have about eleven of them this time.

Follow me closely as we enter into protocol. Whenever these things start pouring through me, I write them down as if I am writing to somebody.

Brother Tim, as I was meditating on Matthew 6, I realized that what Jesus was teaching His disciples was not just prayer alone, but how to enter the presence of God with protocol. It was not only about bearing a scripturally correct petition, but also about thanksgiving and worship.

When I kept hearing the word protocol, I knew He wanted me to know as much about entering His presence as He did about the scriptural content of my petition.

In Matthew 6, when Jesus said that our heavenly Father knows what things we have need of before we pray, I knew that if He already knows what we need before we pray, then how we present Him with our petition must be as important as the petition itself. If I am going to enter the presence of a king, I want to know how to enter correctly.

When I first started hearing the word protocol, I researched it to make sure I was hearing correctly. I wanted to know what protocol had to do with petitionary prayer. Protocol means a preliminary memorandum of diplomatic negotiation.

Where I was familiar with the word protocol was in the case of an ambassador from one country learning the customs of the country to which he was assigned. Long before he entered the presence of the king to begin diplomatic negotiations, he would be thoroughly versed in protocol. Some kings required a certain manner of conduct. Some required bowing. Some required that you not look up until spoken to. In other places, an expensive gift would be considered protocol. But all of it was preliminary to negotiation, and in our case, preliminary to petition.

Notice in Matthew 6 that when Jesus taught His disciples how to pray, there was more instruction on how to approach the Father than there was on the actual prayer itself. Because the Father already knew what they had need of long before they prayed, the presentation of the actual petition did not provide Him with any more information than He already had.

This is why Jesus majored as much on the prerequisites to prayer, the things that must be present in your life when you make your petition, as He did on the petition itself. These prerequisites are as important to answered prayer as the scriptural accuracy of your petition.

Any person versed in protocol would never enter the presence of a king to begin diplomatic negotiations without first finding out what pleased the king and caused him to listen to the petition.

Follow these verses closely, and I can promise you that you will end up pleasing the Father and enjoying a new anointing for answered prayer.

It is with the same respect for protocol that Jesus taught us in entering the presence of the Father that we also use in entering His presence. It is the presence of our King, Jesus. This is what the ministry of the Holy Spirit revealed from the betrayal to the arrest.

From the day you were born again, it was the Holy Spirit who was assigned to bring you into the presence of Jesus. First He did this through the rebirth. In John 3:5, Jesus said:

Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God.

The first assignment of the Holy Spirit is to bring you into His presence. From then on, His ministry in you is to glorify Jesus as He sanctifies you from the world and the world from you, changing you from glory to glory into His image.

That is the job of the Holy Spirit. He sanctifies you from the world until, after a while, your conduct, character, and standards are like Him. When you go into the presence of God using Jesus' name, it is like Him praying.

Second Corinthians 3:18 says:

But we all, with open face beholding as in a glass the glory of the Lord,
are changed into the same image from glory to glory,
even as by the Spirit of the Lord.

It is the Holy Spirit's ministry to bring me into His presence. Nothing glorifies Jesus more than to see you and me changed into His image in both character and standards as He reveals Jesus in us.

I have learned in protocol that long before I enter the presence of God to offer my petition in prayer, I first need to enter the presence of Jesus by the power of the Holy Spirit and worship Him for paying the price that my prayer might be heard. Then, after I have attained to worship at the feet of Jesus, He goes with me to the Father, that I may present my petition to the Father, first in worship and then in prayer.

Jesus said, "The Father Himself loveth you, and whatsoever ye shall ask the Father in My name, He will give it you." It was Jesus Himself, at the cost of His own life, who ransomed Himself for me, that I might have the right to stand in the presence of God and pray.

I will always worship Jesus for this inalienable right that no one can take away.

Hallelujah. Oh, hallelujah.

John 16:23 says:

And in that day ye shall ask me nothing.
Verily, verily, I say unto you,
Whatsoever ye shall ask the Father in my name, he will give it you.

Glory be to God.

The Godhead Is Approached Through the Ministry Each Person Performs

In Matthew 6, Jesus stood there in person and taught His disciples, and at the same time taught us, how to enter the presence of the Father. After His betrayal, He revealed the ministry of the Holy Spirit. As the Holy Spirit takes us in that day into the presence of Jesus, then Jesus, who provided the answer to my prayer, takes us through His name and His presence into the presence of the Father.

What are the prerequisites?

Matthew 6:5 says:

And when thou prayest, thou shalt not be as the hypocrites are:
for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and in the corners of the streets,
that they may be seen of men.
Verily I say unto you, They have their reward.
But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet,
and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret;
and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly.

Let us talk about this for a minute.

Here is the Godhead, and I want to approach God with a petition. There are three persons in the Godhead who make up the one God. Three in person, one in essence. When you say, "I love You, God," you are talking to all three. When you say, "I love You, Father God," you are talking to Jehovah. When you say, "I love You, Jesus," you are talking to the Word, the Logos, the second person of the Godhead. When you say, "I love You, Holy Spirit," and it is all right to say that, you are talking to the third person of the Godhead.

These three are one in essence. In Genesis, when it says, "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth," it is saying that the Godhead, working in one accord, created everything. In John 1, He explains in more detail the roles they took. The Father planned it, the mighty Word created it, and the Holy Spirit regenerates it.

Now I am going to approach this Being with a petition. Flesh and blood, you and I, are going to approach Him with a petition.

Who do you approach first? What does the Holy Spirit do? What does Jesus do? Who is the Father? Who do I approach first? How do I offer my petition? After I have offered it, who do I worship? Who do I thank that it is done? Do I say, "Jesus, I thank You for a miracle," or "Father, I thank You for a miracle"?

I am approaching the Godhead with a petition. How do I do it?

Let us make this important. I am going to approach Him for a lost loved one. Is that important to you?

My friend, complacency is deep-rooted. Complacency is very deep-rooted when it does not bother your prayer life that your close loved ones are on a collision course with hell. If I am going to approach God with a petition for a lost loved one, then for God's sake I want to know how to enter His presence. I want to know that I am heard, and I want to know heaven is in motion when I shut that prayer down.

I do not have any problem knowing, because I know first of all that He is not a man that He should lie. I know that when I pray, He hears me.

The Cost of Redemption Demands Reverent Worship

I want to sober you a little.

I know Jesus suffered and died in my place as my substitute. I know He died on the cross and my judgment was on Him. I know He became the curse of the law. I also know that after He became my sin, He had to suffer the penalty for becoming my sin.

In other words, it was not enough for Him to become my sin. There was judgment and punishment for becoming my sin. As Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so must the Son of Man be in the heart of the earth.

Find out why Jonah was in the belly of the whale three days and three nights. When he was on the ship and the ship was sinking because Jonah was running from God, he admitted to them, "If you sacrifice me and throw me overboard, you yourselves will be saved." He substituted his life for theirs, just like Jesus did for yours. They threw him overboard, and a great fish swallowed him and carried him down into the depths. Jonah cried from the belly of hell. God heard him, delivered him, and he was spit upon the shore of the Ninevites. He resurrected, preached to them, and they repented.

Hallelujah. Glory be to God.

One time Kenneth Copeland preached that message, from the cross, through Jesus' death, to the time He sat down at the right hand of the Father. He put Jesus in a deep, dark place in the earth. I was meditating and preaching that message, and right in the middle of a service I went into an open vision. The crowd disappeared, and I was standing there looking into the vision. There was no more crowd. The vision was in front of me.

I found myself looking into a cavern, a deep, dark place. The roof looked concave. It was so pitch black that anything conscious in this place would be in a state of listlessness and loneliness. As I stood looking into it, that is what I picked up in my spirit. I went into a state of listlessness, as if I were eternally damned to that lonely state of agony.

Then, as I could see into this cavern, I saw a man lying flat on his back. Do not ask me how God can do this. I do not know. It was pitch black, but I could see him. His outline was illuminated. This man was lying flat on his back with his arms lifted up. Remember, in my message I had just sent Jesus, according to Jonah, into the center of the earth because I was about to resurrect Him.

I had just put Jesus in this place in the center, according to Psalm 88, and was about to get Him out. Now I was looking into hell or something, and there was this man lying flat on his back with his arms lifted. Although I could not really hear the screams, I could feel them. I could feel what they were saying. He was opening and closing his hands, crying, "Help me, help me, help me." As Psalm 88 said, he was crying by reason of his infirmity.

Then somehow I could see what was covering his body. At this point I lose a lot of people. I cannot help what I see under an anointing. There were worms covering his body. By all appearance, they were consuming him alive. They covered his body so much that he was distorted to look at.

Isaiah 52 leading into Isaiah 53 says:

As many were astonished at thee;
his visage was so marred more than any man,
and his form more than the sons of men.

Under the darkness of that cloud, when the whole earth turned dark, Jesus cried, "My God, why hast Thou forsaken Me?" He became every broken piece of humanity that you and I were. This thing I saw was distorted. Isaiah said His visible appearance was marred more than any man and His form more than the sons of men.

If it says His form was marred, the part that makes me a man is my form. I have the form of a man. If His form was marred more than the sons of men, I can tell you why. It means that the form that made Him a man was so altered by every broken piece of humanity He had become that there has never been a child born in any generation with any deformity whose form was altered more than His was that day.

Again, He bore your sickness and carried your pains so you could be healed. Nobody has ever loved you like Him.

I saw the worms covering His body, and then I snapped out of it. I was standing there in front of the crowd with my mouth open, still in the position I had gone into. I thought I had been there for a while, but they said it was just a pause for a moment.

I came out of it so shocked. I said, "Jesus, You will have to give me verses. If this is You suffering for me in the center of the earth, according to Jonah, if this is You, You will have to give me verses. I have been taught against this."

Then I said, "Jesus, You are my whitewashed Lamb. It did not cost You much to redeem me. You were barely touched. It did not cost much to lay my sin on You."

Why should I stop there? He said they will be cast into outer darkness where there is gnashing of teeth and their worm dieth not.

Either He suffered the penalty for becoming my sin, or He did not. If He did, do you think it was a picnic? Do you think the price tag on your righteousness came cheap?

When you approach the presence of your King, do it with respect. The less we think it cost Him, the more we think we can get by with.

Worship Requires the Whole Soul, Not the Sound of a Religious Voice

Jesus said, "When you enter His presence, be not as the hypocrites." They stand in church praying. To what? To hear their own voice? Because everybody is praying and somebody next to them might be watching?

How do you pray over your meals anymore? To hear your own voice? What is the condition of the heart?

When we enter His presence to petition Him, to ask Him something, what part of us entered in? It is just as easy to stand in the synagogue and do what everybody else is doing as not. That is why He said, "Be not as the hypocrites." They pray to be seen of men.

I want to know how to enter Jesus' presence. If it is the Holy Spirit who takes me in, and Jesus, with His name, takes me into the presence of the Father, then I want to know how to enter the presence of Jesus my King without hypocrisy.

When I start worshiping Him, He is going to get every part of me. My mind is not going to be off at some picnic. I will not worship Him just to hear the sound of my voice. He has me. For those fifteen minutes I worship Him, He has me. If I am singing with the worship team, then I am pouring everything into every lyric. He has me. I am not singing to hear my own voice.

How will I enter His presence? I will say, "Holy Spirit, I need You to teach me something. Holy Spirit, I need You to teach me how to offer my soul in worship, all of me. My soul is my mind, my will, my intellect, and my emotions. I need to know how to offer all of me."

I will tell you this much today: I am not going to allow my mind to be doing anything else while I am learning to worship. I am not allowing my intellect to solve some other problem. I am not allowing my emotions to go on some other trip. No more will my will be allowed to switch me off worship onto something else. I will not allow it.

If I am going to take fifteen minutes to enter Jesus' presence, then He is going to get all of me for those fifteen minutes.

At first it was difficult because the veil of flesh was so thick, whether in public worship or private worship. It is hard to step through it into His presence. It took me a while. My mind, will, intellect, and emotions wanted to wander around the room while I wanted to stand there and worship God.

I would hear myself saying, "I love You, Jesus. I worship You. I glorify You, Jesus. I love You, Jesus." Pretty soon I would hear my voice going, "I love You, Jesus," while my mind was off solving something else.

So I learned protocol. I learned how to pull it back. If it took ten seconds to collect my whole soul and bring it back to attention, then when I said one simple statement, "I love You, Jesus; I worship and adore You," for that burst of adoration I poured everything my soul was into that statement of worship.

If I found myself wandering again after that, I would stop. If it took five seconds to collect my soul back again, I would pour it back into the statement of adoration.

I had to do that for about fifteen minutes. Then something happened. The Holy Spirit got involved. He rose up and helped me. Pretty soon I started flowing in the Spirit. I did not have to try to think of statements of adoration. The only thing I had to figure out was how to stop so I could present a petition.

It was glorious.

Worship Jesus for the Finished Work Before Presenting the Petition to the Father

After about fifteen minutes of worshiping and glorifying Jesus, I stopped and said, "Jesus, I have this petition I need to offer. I need it answered. I want to thank You, while You were on earth, for teaching me how to enter the presence of the Father. Now I am going to bear this petition into His presence.

"I have just spent fifteen minutes worshiping You because You paid the price for Him to hear this petition. How can I say thanks, Jesus, for putting my feet on this path? How can I say thanks for writing my name in heaven and paying the price? I worship You, love You, and adore You, my Jesus. Now I thank You for coming with me. I am going to present this petition before the Father in Your name."

But before I present it, I take those prerequisites and enter the presence of the Father with, "Hallowed be Thy name." I worship Him for ten or fifteen minutes the same way I worshiped Jesus.

"I love You, Father. I glorify You. Hallelujah. I adore You. I magnify You. I want to thank You. I praise You. Hallelujah."

Yah is Jehovah. Yahweh is worshiped. Hallelujah means praise without end, innumerable praises.

Then I get my petition out and read it to Him, not because He does not know what is in it. The prerequisites are to give Him the respect due Him. He knows what is in it. Protocol is to enter His presence correctly.

So we are covering this part right now. I get my petition out and give the name of the person:

"Father, I am receiving this person into the kingdom. In the name of Jesus, I want to thank You for their salvation because You are not a man that You should lie. Psalm 2 says that immediately after You were begotten of God, the first thing You did was ask for the heathen for Your inheritance. I know You want them saved as badly as I do, so I am going to join in prayer, fellowship, and agreement with Jesus for my lost loved one. I receive them into the kingdom.

"Father, I thank You. I receive them into the kingdom, and I make this faith statement: when I get to heaven, they will either have preceded me or they will follow me, but they will be in heaven with me."

Then I begin to worship Him and thank Him that it is done. I vacillate between Jesus and the Father:

"Thank You, Jesus. I worship You for providing for it. Thank You, Jesus, that it is done because You finished the work.

"Father, I thank You for hearing the petition.

"Holy Spirit, I thank You for carrying it out."

Hallelujah.

Then here come the angels. God will tap born-again doctors on the shoulder and say, "Move to Timbuktu."

"Why?"

"Because so-and-so just prayed the prayer of faith for her doctor son, and he needs a Christian with your values that he can believe in. So I am moving you across the country to Timbuktu, right next to her doctor son, to take up residency so he can get born again."

Then He stations angels around him for a conducive atmosphere. The angels watch out for him. He will not be able to kill himself or die or anything else until God has thoroughly dealt with him for many, many years.

Petitionary prayer.

Did you learn anything?